

Month 1: Baseline Security & Core Architecture

Daily roadmap balancing Jeremy's IT Lab (CCNA), Prof. Messer (Sec+), and Hands-on Tooling.

The Strategy

You cannot secure what you do not understand. This month focuses on building an unshakeable foundation in how networks operate (Cisco/CCNA concepts) and the baseline security controls placed over them (Security+). You will use Cisco Packet Tracer to build virtual networks and Wireshark to inspect the traffic.

Bonus Free Certifications to Add to Your Roadmap:

- **ISC2 Certified in Cybersecurity (CC):** The strongest free entry-level certification available. ISC2 provides free self-paced online training and a free exam voucher. It carries immediate credibility because it is backed by the organization behind the CISSP.
- **Cisco NetAcad - Junior Cybersecurity Analyst:** Since you are already learning CCNA concepts, this 120-hour free pathway from Cisco aligns perfectly and offers verifiable digital badges.

Weekly Syllabus Breakdown

- **Week 1 (Network Fundamentals & Core Threats):** Introduction to the OSI model, IP addressing, and subnetting via Jeremy's IT Lab. Supplemented with Prof. Messer's breakdown of security roles and threat actors. *Lab focus: Basic Packet Tracer LANs.*

- **Week 2 (Switching, VLANs, & Malware):** Deep dive into Cisco switches and segmenting networks using VLANs. Learning how malware operates and moves laterally across these networks. *Lab focus: Configuring VLANs in Packet Tracer.*
- **Week 3 (Routing & Traffic Inspection):** Understanding static and dynamic routing between subnets (Router on a Stick). Transitioning into active traffic analysis. *Lab focus: Inter-VLAN routing in Packet Tracer and raw packet inspection using Wireshark.*
- **Week 4 (Access Control & Network Services):** Understanding how DNS/DHCP operate, and how to restrict traffic using Access Control Lists (ACLs). *Lab focus: Applying ACLs in Packet Tracer and documenting the architecture on GitHub.*

Tooling & Workflow

- **Anki:** Use Anki daily to memorize port numbers, OSI layers, and Security+ acronyms. Spaced repetition is crucial here.
- **GitHub Documentation:** Whenever you build a topology in Packet Tracer (like a segmented VLAN network), take screenshots, export the `.pkt` file, and upload it to GitHub with a README explaining the routing logic and security benefits.